

CHANNELING THE SPIRITS

mediums and séances

By the turn of the 20th century the medium-directed séance was cemented in popular culture. Séances were demonstrations during which mediums supposedly channeled spirits, acting as intermediaries between those spirits and members of the audience. These increasingly dramatic events came to feature tables turning and floating as well as Ouija boards (see pp.230–231), while mediums often entered trance-like states before speaking or writing on the spirits' behalf. Such shows became full of thrilling theatrical excess, playing to the 19th-century love of stage magic.

Trance speaking

Numerous mediums claimed to channel the words of spirits while in a state of trance. In the US, the spiritualist Leonora Piper described her trances as being “as if something were passing over my brain making it numb.” In this state, her changed voice and appearance convinced onlookers that she was inhabited by another persona. Such personas were often believed to be spirit controls who were themselves intermediaries between Leonora and the spirits of other deceased people. Another high-profile American medium, Cora L.V. Scott, gained fame in the later 1800s as a beautiful, inspirational speaker on a wide range of topics, and apparently spoke while in a trance as the spirits moved her.

◀ Talking tables

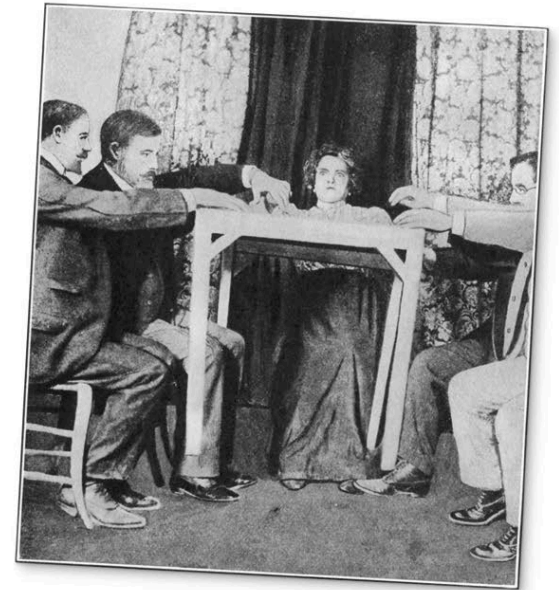
One of the many spiritualist publications in circulation at the time, this 1909 edition of *La Vie mystérieuse* has a feature on table-turning or *tables parlantes* (talking tables).

► Looking into the future

Crystal-gazing was a staple of popular spiritualism. After elaborate cleaning of the crystal ball, practitioners would peer into it to divine the future, or to see lost loved ones.

Materialization

French medium Eva Carrière appeared to conjure ghostly figures and produce ectoplasm (a spiritual manifestation) from her naked body. There was skepticism about such tricks, and after an investigation Carrière was exposed as a fraud: her spirits were cardboard cut-outs, and her ectoplasm was chewed paper.



▲ The spirits rise up

One of celebrated Italian medium Eusapia Palladino's talents was making tables levitate. This picture dates from 1892 when a major investigation of her methods was underway, and it was concluded that her practices were clever tricks rather than supernatural phenomena.

Spirit messages

Table-turning was all the rage. People sat with their hands on a table, which would seemingly tilt, rise, or rotate as a means of communication from spirits of the departed. For example, a spirit message might be spelled out by a medium saying letters of the alphabet aloud and certain letters apparently making the table move. Such movements could be explained by the “ideomotor effect,” where simply thinking about a kind of motion causes involuntary physical responses that end up making it happen, without subjects having taken any conscious choice to move.

